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The Jazz Business

Jazz is not only a way of making music, but also one of making profits. Few of the popular arts have been subsidized, whether by public or private patronage. Mostly, like jazz, they have been forms of commercial entertainment by professional artists hired by various kinds of private entrepreneurs. Box-office and sales chart are what determine the movements of such arts and the fate of the artists. What the jazz-lover hears, therefore, depends not only on the creative urges of the musicians and other imponderables, but on the way jazz is organized as a business. In this and the subsequent chapter I shall explain briefly how jazz functions as a business and technical enterprise, and how this affects it musically and in other ways. Readers who believe that records make themselves and that horn players are fed by ravens sent down from heaven, like the prophet Elijah, are advised to pick themselves a less earthbound music to admire.

Jazz musicians are professionals. The prejudice against 'commercialism' among a large section of the jazz public makes it necessary to repeat this obvious truth. Jazz may be in its origins and character a folk-music, but this does not mean that it is an art of amateurs. Even in the countryside much of folk-art is professionalized—the art of minstrels, jugglers, or wandering showmen, not to mention such virtually specialized artists as certain religious functionaries, or the fiddler who gives the tune for capstan shanties, the black convict whose work consists of 'song-leading' for labour gangs. The prehistory of jazz is full of such primitive professionals, of whom one particularly vigorous and murderous one, the late Huddie Ledbetter ('Leadbelly') is widely known thanks to the records he made for the Library of Congress in Washington. Every connoisseur can reel off long lists of the names of such artists, as often as not blind men who, from combining begging with

music, graduate, like Homer before them, into full-time art: Blind Blake, Blind Boy Fuller, Blind Lemon Jefferson, Blind Willie Johnson. They are itinerant, because no place in the country provides enough work for the settled professional.

The city however does, and jazz is from its beginnings a music of the city poor. Not only does the city provide such professionalism, it demands it. Its style of life is more specialized, less traditional than country life, where the arts are for the most part closely tied to the various specific occasions and aspects of life, and almost unthinkable apart from them, and therefore perforce largely amateur. It is no accident that the W.P.A. guide book to the state of Mississippi reported in the 1930s that 'because of the increasing influence of the city upon the Negro and the resulting departure from the simple life, the number of social songs has increased with a proportionate decrease in the number of spirituals and work-songs'. The city tends to split the artist from the citizen, and to turn most of the arts into 'entertainment', a special need supplied by specialists. Moreover, the city's demands on entertainment, because more specialized, are much higher than the country's. Ever since ancient Athens it has been a complaint against it that townsmen 'always want something new'; it might with equal justice be observed that the city insists on higher standards, because it has more chance of comparison, and because it does not need to measure the performer by the amateur's capacities. At all events, regular entertainment even in the pre-industrial city is almost invariably professional:^{*} this applies to singers, musicians, sportsmen, showmen, and extra-marital sex, for prostitution is an urban, not a rural phenomenon. Even when an artistic movement begins as a deliberate revolt against commercialism and professionalization, like the 'New Orleans Revival' in America during the war, and in Europe after it, it cannot resist the force of facts, at any rate if it appeals to the public. Within the last few years every successful British 'New Orleans' band leader and musician has had to choose between his normal occupation and his music. Some have chosen their jobs, others have become full-time professional musicians. The ideal of a permanent and widely popular amateur music has not resisted the technical impossibility of bucking the social division of labour.

The folk-artists who made jazz had no romantic nonsense about the virtues of amateurism in them. They became professionals as soon as they could earn a living at their music, when they did not already come from show-business families. In the early days of New Orleans we can still see this group of professionals emerging from part-time music. However, for practical purposes professionalism can be regarded as established from the first decades of the 1900s. As we have seen, this development, the competition of craftsmen within their community and their separation from the rest of the people, has affected the actual musical evolution of jazz very considerably.

These professionals have earned their living in three different, but related, types of economic setting: pre-industrial entertainment, the modern entertainment industry, and the specialized jazz business. The first two of these have no particular connexions with jazz, except that of selling it to the public if there is a demand for it, as they sell the spectacle of bearded ladies imitating steam whistles, girls with big busts kicking or not kicking their legs, the latest mass murderer, or musical genius. The last deals exclusively in jazz, for it has developed out of the discovery that there is a paying public for this specific type of entertainment. Most of the European jazz musician's living today comes out of the jazz business, though in the U.S.A. this is probably not yet the case.

If we compare the commercial outlets for jazz at the peak of the golden age of 1960 with those in the New Orleans period, we find three major differences: first, some of the traditional ones have declined; second, the new technical media (gramophones, radio, films, TV, etc.) have grown tremendously; third, and most striking, a specialized public for jazz as such has emerged.

A great deal of jazz is still played, economically, in very much the same way as in the days of King Oliver: in night clubs, for dances, and on the stage. Indeed, the honky-tonk, or bar room, or night club—especially the less classy type of joint—still remains an essential pillar of the music, especially in the United States, where the specialist jazz public is less organized than in Europe. New and experimental players can get a start in joints more easily than in most other places. They can be got cheap (in a London joint I know first-rate, but ‘uncommercial’, musicians will play five or six hours for £3 each), the patrons do not mind what

noise comes from the stand so long as there are drinks and girls, and, also, in every entertainment quarter there have always been one or two saloon keepers, club owners, or madams who genuinely liked either musicians or the new kind of music even at the cost of a few bad debts and a certain amount of nerve strain. Such were Tom Turpin in the St Louis or ragtime (himself no mean piano player), Lulu White, Madame Mame de Ware, 'Ready Money', the Countess Willie Piazza, and other notable madams of the early century, 'Pee-Wee' on Beale Street, Memphis, 'The Chief' in Kansas City, Henry Minton in New York (himself an ex-musician and Musicians' Union official). These and other unsung patrons of the lively arts, showed a more enterprising taste than most of their orthodox contemporaries.¹ Similarly, unfashionable players can get a berth in such places. In New York today many of the great names of the thirties manage to make ends meet by playing behind the bar in saloons. On the other hand, that other great standby of the early jazz musicians, the music-hall or vaudeville stage, has declined precipitously. In America it is virtually extinct, and in so far as it survives in Europe, it is as a purely secondary medium which exhibits jazz artists who have made their name elsewhere. In the early thirties the visiting jazz musician normally topped a variety bill (as he still does, if lucky, in the Paris Olympia); today—unless he has special music-hall qualifications—he plays almost entirely for the organized jazz public. No new jazz talent in Europe has been discovered through the 'halls', and none in America since the war.

The new technical media—records, radio, etc.—have been of fundamental importance for jazz, but not—odd though this may seem—for directly financial reasons. Financially, radio, TV, and the films have provided a living for jazzmen as pop-music players, and an occasional windfall, or even bonanza, for bands hired to play jazz, or put into a film. (But the proportion of films containing jazz has been negligible until the middle fifties, and most of them were shorts.) Radio, with its greater capacity to cater for minority taste, has been kinder to live jazzmen, though not as kind as to recorded ones. Though film and, in America, TV fees have been high, especially for name bands, live broadcasting fees in Europe were and are modest. On the other hand, the advertisement value

of the mass media has always been so great that any sensible musician is prepared to settle for a non-economic price, if he has to. Since the decline of vaudeville virtually all national and international reputations have been made by or through broadcasting, which in Europe reaches national audiences. A show on the air, a mention by a popular disc jockey, are by far the quickest ways of popularizing musicians or pieces of music.

Nor is the gramophone record as lucrative as it seems, at least to the musicians, though it is far and away the most important medium in jazz. The leading American jazz musician who shocked British journalists by claiming not to care or know how many records he sold was not merely putting on an act: his group's main income came from live performances. Jazz musicians, or the ranks of the virtually full-time 'session' players in a small minority of cases, enter the stratosphere of the 'top ten' only by accident. However, the gramophone record is so vital a part of the business that it is worth looking at its economics a little more closely.¹

The musician himself normally receives a straight session fee. A British name artist may get a 5 per cent royalty, plus a share of the 6¼ per cent 'mechanical royalties' which bodies like the Performing Rights Society, ASCAP, and BIEM negotiate and collect in complicated ways, assuming that he also gets his name on the labels in some other capacity (as composer, arranger, etc.). These cover the innumerable performances of a record on the air or on jukeboxes, films, etc. A man in steady demand on sessions—sometimes indeed, employed as a regular 'house' or 'studio' musician by a company—can do extremely well. For instance, in America a single drummer, Mr. Osie Johnson, could appear in a single year in 233 tracks made at forty-six different sessions. However, the number of highly prosperous session men is limited. In the same year in America equally useful but less fashionable drummers such as Shadow Wilson and Specs Powell appeared on only four and two sessions respectively,² and in Britain the same few dozen names permute and combine on ninety per cent of all native jazz records.

The royalty income (which affects, substantially, only the bandleader, composer, arranger, or star soloist) naturally depends on record sales, as do the profits of the various entrepreneurs. Small though the percentage is at home, and even smaller on foreign rights, a genuine best-seller, or a

regular succession of steady sellers, produce a very tidy income. How tidy, those who earn it are reluctant to say, though that downright Lancashire ex-workingman, Jack Hylton, once gave details of how much he earned in his heyday in the 1920s and early 1930s: he drew \$116,000 from HMV in recording royalties for 1929, and a guaranteed \$232,000 for the next two years from Decca.³ Admittedly Hylton was not only the unchallenged emperor of European dance bands, but a very shrewd man into the bargain. At the other extreme there are jazz records which sell considerably less than the 1,000–1,500 which covers the cost of making an LP in 1957–8; for instance, a record made annually on contract by a modern jazz musician, now turned arranger, sold precisely 386 copies in Britain. The only consolation for all concerned is that the demand for jazz records (unlike ordinary pop discs) is permanent. If a company is willing to tie up space and capital in them, they continue to sell to new generations of fans. There are old-fashioned 78 rpm jazz records which have never been out of print since they were first released ten or twenty years ago, though they have probably never sold more than 2,000 copies on average per year.

Fortunately jazz records have this permanence and are fairly cheap to make,⁴ since they generally require few musicians: allowing for retakes, four or five single sides or tracks can be made in a session. It has therefore normally been worth producing relatively uncommercial jazz records, even at inflated prices and production costs. At a guess, even in 1958 a cheap single record would certainly cover its cost with a sale of 2,000 or less and produce a modest profit with a sale of 4,000. Reissues of foreign or old records are naturally a great deal cheaper.

Jazz records therefore become ‘commercial’ in two ways: either because they are saleable in the open market, like any other pop record, but with the advantage that unsold stock does not become valueless in a month or two; or when there is a sufficiently large public of aficionados existing to guarantee them a steady, if modest sale of, let us say, 1,000 to 1,500 copies. Until the later 1930s this latter possibility depended on convincing the commercial gramophone companies of the existence of a jazz public. This was done, with notable success in Britain, by a combination of pressure from outside—especially from the dance-music

press—and from inside, by the fifth column of jazz-lovers in the dance-music business who had the ear of the companies. From the later thirties enthusiastic American amateurs began to reissue old discs and later to record live jazz directly for the aficionado public on small private labels or for ‘hot record societies’, a practice taken up after the war in Europe. Several of these private labels and catalogues were eventually taken over by the commercial companies, or developed into commercial labels.

The jazz market for gramophone records has also benefited from the peculiar internationalism of the jazz public. To some extent small sales in one country can be supplemented by the accumulated small sales of several others. For instance, records by King Oliver have been issued in the U.S.A., Canada, the Argentine, France, Britain, Germany, Switzerland, Czechoslovakia, Sweden, Denmark, Italy, the Netherlands, Australia, and Japan. His *Blue Blood Blues* was released by Columbia in France, Britain, Australia, and Switzerland; his *Snake Rag* reprinted in America, France, Britain, the Netherlands, and Australia.⁴ A record which just breaks even in Britain may therefore still earn decent royalties by Scandinavian, Dutch, or Japanese sales.

B. LONG-PLAYING RECORD

Selling-price (1958)	per copy \$4.20
Cost per copy: Distribution (52½%)	1.58
Sleeve	0.35
Pressing, material, label	0.28
Artist's Royalty (5%)	0.15
Mechanical Royalties (6¼%)	0.19
Musicians (10 men for 2 sessions), \$291.20 at 1,000 sales	per copy 0.175
Studio costs \$224.00 at 1,000 sales	per copy 0.13
Purchase Tax	1.05
Maker's Margin, overheads, publicity	0.30
Break-even point: say 1,200 sales	

The cost of printing the sleeve assumes a run of 1,500. The estimates are of course approximate and perhaps pessimistic. They come from a very

experienced record producer. An American estimate for 1960 is more ambitious. It sets the actual break-even point for an LP made by a small company at 3,000 sales and for a large one at 7,000. (The average sale, however, is given at only 2,000 copies, which suggests that some LPs can still be made very cheaply.)

Outside and by now perhaps also inside America the most important source of jazz and of livelihood for jazz players is today the specialist jazz public, or the institutions which have grown out of it: the jazz club (which began, essentially, as a club for listening rather than dancing to jazz), the jazz concert, and the specialized jazz record or broadcast. Most of these were first set up on a non-commercial basis by amateurs to meet the demand of other amateurs, or at most by commercial undertakings on the passionate promptings of amateurs. As jazz has become a more paying proposition, a business structure has grown up around this non-commercial nucleus, but it is largely distinct from the normal apparatus of show business. Its entrepreneurs, agents, impresarios, recording advisers, dealers, organizers, etc., are mostly former fans, critics, and musicians who have drifted into business with the tide of jazz popularity, all the more so because the established businessmen in the entertainment world lacked at first the interest, and later the know-how, to tap the jazz market. Collectors of the 1930s look after the jazz catalogues of the big American and British recording companies. The leading agency for jazz musicians in Britain is filled with former collectors, critics, pioneer jazz musicians, and others. A typical 'fan' organization, the National Jazz Federation (non-profit-making), originally a federation of jazz clubs, developed into a major organizer of jazz concerts, tours for visiting artists, and jazz clubs, while in America an *avant-garde* aficionado of considerable shrewdness, Mr Norman Granz, succeeded in the ten years after the war in building himself a sizeable business empire on the dual foundation of a permanent concert road show of front-line musicians ('Jazz at the Philharmonic'), and a cast-iron catalogue of recording artists which he distributed on highly favourable terms (and under his own name and labels) through big companies when they came to need a jazz catalogue. It is rather as though poetry suddenly became a commercial

proposition, and former poets, reviewers, and organizers of poetry circles, found themselves putting cigars in their mouths, taking planes to the U.S.A. (or Europe respectively), and indulging in conspicuous expenditure in domestic cocktail bars and hi-fi. Business is business, but the jazz businessmen often still show marked traces of their non-commercial past: a passionate hostility to the colour bar, a marked tendency to sympathize with left-wing politics, and an occasional willingness to subsidize wholly non-commercial music, if it is 'good jazz'.

The extent of the 'specialist' demand for jazz may be gauged by the fact that an issue of the British *Melody Maker*, chosen at random early in 1958, listed *seventy* different clubs or other locations where live jazz was played between one and seven nights weekly in London and the Home Counties; not counting nine other jazz concerts, jazz artists appearing on ordinary music-hall bills, the numerous (unadvertised) sessions of skiffle music and the like in various coffee bars, and various unadvertised clubs which employed jazz musicians. In the same week, and in the same area, there were five live jazz broadcasts on sound radio and none on TV. In America this specialized demand has always been much smaller, and perhaps more concentrated in the universities which have provided the most systematic engagements for adventurous jazz groups, but even there, especially in the later 1930s and 1940s, clubs and other joints combining commercial enterprise with a strong backing by the aficionados were rather important outlets for good jazz: for instance, Café Society Downtown in Greenwich village, which was for long a showcase for new jazz discoveries, and 'Nicks', which catered for the middle-aged intellectuals attempting to recapture their Dixieland youth. In France the aficionado clubs multiplied after 1944 in and around the Saint Germain quarter, though they soon became commercialized, charging very high prices to all except a selected group of students who were let in free to create atmosphere. However, a cheaper alternative, the so-called *discothèque* clubs, which played exclusively jazz records, seem to have been more successful there than in other countries.

The specialist market has also produced a number of institutions patterned on the 'art-music' business, and of varying commercial importance: 'jazz festivals'—in Newport, Conn., in Nice, Cannes, San

Remo, and other European holiday resorts—and, more recently in America, the university jazz recital and summer school. From the musician's point of view these are spiritually rather than financially satisfactory, like the occasional recitals in the temples of official music, the Carnegie Hall, the Festival Hall, or the Salle Pleyel. They are a sort of cultural recognition of jazz, but too infrequent to count much. On the other hand, the organized concert tour has become the standby of many a jazz combination. Such tours are today much more speculative propositions than in the happy days before TV, when the touring band might play perhaps a quarter of their time as a variety show in cinemas, sheltered by the wings of the great stars, and the rest of the time strictly for dancing in roadhouses and ballrooms. But the decline of the cinema and of the American ballroom deprived the touring band of its fixed public and largely killed the increasingly expensive big band: during their heyday it was possible to hire a good sideman for the road for about \$50 a week, but 1960 scale (i.e. the Musicians' Union minimum) for an eighteen-piece band was \$2,700 a week.⁵ Given the cost of top talent and the smallness of the jazz public outside a few big cities, the concert tour is risky, even though the wise promoter will reject any deal that will not allow him to make money on a sixty per cent house. In consequence few jazz groups or shows could rely entirely on such tours even if they wanted to.⁸

It will be evident that the average jazz player gets his income—which is not normally a straight salary—in bits and pieces: a gig here, a longer engagement there, a radio programme, a recording session, with luck a basic band salary to fall back on. Even if he has that, he must move about constantly, for in spite of the great increase in the jazz public, a band can rarely stay more than a few weeks in the same location. Not for the jazz audience the loyalty of the dance-palais, whose customers dance to the same band for decades. In London, at the time of writing, only two clubs rely primarily on the same band night after night; and those are profoundly 'traditionalist' jazz clubs, i.e. clubs playing what has by now become chiefly a dancing music. A band, and especially an expensive large band, *must* travel. Casual work and travel are therefore built into the

jazzman's economy, especially if he wants to earn more than the barest minimum.

This is all the more so because the foundations of that economy are extremely fragile. The leading player of today, like the leading actor, may be forgotten tomorrow. In America, the small jazz combination has, until recently, *never* lasted for more than a few weeks or months, though the post-war tendency to turn jazz into an art-music which appeals to a public analogous to that for classical chamber music, but larger, has produced lasting small groups: the Dave Brubeck Quartet since 1951, the Modern Jazz Quartet since 1954. Norman Granz's road show, aptly named 'Jazz at the Philharmonic', was the first to tap this concert public systematically in 1946. There has so far been only a single example of a permanent large jazz band: Duke Ellington's, which has had a continuous existence since 1926 and includes at least one player who has been with the band since then, and several who have had continuous stretches of ten years or more with it. In all but two big bands the turnover of personnel has been high. (British bands, as one might expect, have been much more stable, being built largely on the 'fan' public: Humphrey Lyttelton has had a band continuously for twelve years, which is about as long as is possible in the short history of British home-made jazz.) There are both economic and psychological reasons for this instability. To run a jazz band, especially a large one, for any length of time as a paying proposition is extremely difficult, and requires gifts of organization, leadership, and business shrewdness which few musicians possess.

Permanent attachment to a band also compels players to live one of the worst of all kinds of professional life, that of the touring artist, often passing through a succession of one-night stands. And even when the constant rootlessness happens to suit musicians, who may hate to be tied down, it is more than offset by the routine and discipline without which no permanent organization can work, but which freely improvising artists don't like. The good and permanent band is normally run by a martinet, or a 'natural' front man with an eye to the public. Few jazz musicians like this for their instincts are anarchist. All 'natural' sidemen dream of a combo in which nobody will be leader, and everybody will always play as he feels, a band of brothers. But this, as long experience has shown, is a certain guarantee of rapid failure and disintegration.

The bulk of jazz players therefore have a footloose and casual playing career, shifting from band to band and place to place, interspersing their temporary attachment to some establishment with periods of freelancing, and combining it all with recording, casual gigs, and anything else that is going. The musical biography of most players shows this pattern. At one extreme are the few solid, steady men who stay with the same band year in year out, headed by Harry Carney whose thirty-three years with Ellington are almost certainly the world record; at the other the anti-organization men like the clarinetist Pee-Wee Russell 'playing with so great a variety of combos that complete documentation would be impossible';⁶ in between come the rest, but nearer the Russell end of the spectrum than the Carney end. Financially it is not a bad life for a good musician who is widely known in the profession, and moderately reliable in turning up for work (that is to say who is not too drunk, too much addicted to drugs, or too generally crazy and irresponsible to do so). Irresponsibility is more common among white musicians who have graduated into the profession from being amateur aficionados and among some groups of the 'modernist' revolutionaries than among the old-fashioned black players, or white players with a dance-band background, who have the actor's professional conscientiousness on the job. The heart-rending stories of first-class musicians discovered starving on park benches have normally reflected not so much objective economic conditions, but the lack of foresight of the musicians themselves, or their stubbornness in refusing to play any but their own type of music, or their unemployability. Good unknown musicians have sometimes failed to break in; unadaptable ones playing or singing in an idiom which went out of fashion, have often failed to maintain themselves; and a large cloud of second-rank, semi-professional, and occasional players, such as surrounds the core in any casual profession, have even more frequently known genuinely hard times. But the jazz profession is relatively small, relatively open, and very full indeed of camaraderie and craftsmanship. Every good player is a discoverer of talent. Most good players know one another and put one another in the way of jobs. And jobs—even those out of the limelight—are very reasonably paid when times are good. On the other hand, such reflections miss the point. Secondary poverty is built

into the world of jazz, because it is, like acting or other types of show business, a world of casual labour which encourages free spending and discourages rational economic behaviour. Such a world contains men and women who put enough by in times of prosperity to survive, or who have sense enough at the crucial moment to abandon playing in bands for some less impermanent work—arranging, regular studio work, setting up in business. But it also, and in greater numbers, breeds the sort of musician who forgets that \$280 a week basic salaries (which is what a first-rate dance-band musician might earn in England in the early thirties) do not last, or who does not care whether they last.

Through this loose, shifting, small-scale, anarchic world the musician makes his way with the help or burden of a complex network of businessmen, whom he carries: agents, managers, publicity men, bookers, and the rest. Before the rise of the specialist jazz public these were normally ordinary entrepreneurs, for whom the musician was a simple ‘property’; often entrepreneurs of the shady type which is bred in that zone between the day world and the night world, in which gangsters, gamblers, pimps, fight-promoters, and other purveyors of night-time entertainments and services exist. This is a zone of, at best, a certain boozy paternalism, and at worst, of buyers, sellers, and intermediaries who would make a fast buck out of their sisters, and pretend that they had only made fifty cents. The sullen, wary, but hidden hostility of musicians to the entrepreneurs and intermediaries is the reflection of generations of agents who took thirty per cent and ‘managerial’ fees, of gangster club-owners who laughed at union scales and hours, of bookers whose blacklist could kill an artist, of engagements for women artists which came at the end of a series of beds. One of the leading American entrepreneurs began his professional career as manager of night clubs in Al Capone’s Chicago. Any American musician can tell of towns—including New York—in which engagements in the leading night spots and dance halls depended, and in some instances still depend, on the say-so of racketeers: it is a milieu beside which even the classical Hollywood film industry is relatively civilized, and which can be compared only with the milieu in which the fight business flourishes. In Europe the environment of the jazz business, even in its early days, was perhaps less dramatic, but no closer to the business ethics of the Sunday school. The

rise of the specialist jazz public, and with it of businessmen who—whatever their other characteristics—have often been brought up as aficionados, has improved the situation somewhat. There are even examples of men who, like John Hammond, Jr, in America, have acted as remarkably efficient talent scouts, advisers, publicity men, and business intermediaries for an army of musicians without making or desiring to make money out of them. But if the worst examples of exploitation have perhaps retreated to the fringes of the jazz field, there is enough left over to preserve the musicians' suspicious and generalized cynicism about those in the business who do not play instruments, but on whose 'goodwill' the player depends. It can be broken down, but not easily. It is hard for the musician to feel that he is not surrounded at all times by fools (the ignorant fans) and knaves (the businessmen, publicists, etc.), all of whom have a right to the business smile, the thousandth pose for the thousandth photograph which looks like all the others, the phoney heartiness which may buy a chance, a job, a raise, a renewal of a contract, or a line of free publicity.

It is therefore natural that so anarchic a business should have developed trade-union and self-defence organizations, though a little surprising that so intractable a body of men and women as the entertainers should have succeeded in building strong ones: and the British Musicians' Union and American Federation of Musicians are very powerful indeed, as are the organizations of composers, writers, and others, ASCAP and the Performing Rights Society. Possibly in Britain the strength of the union derives from the working-class background of the profession, in America from techniques into which it would be best not to inquire; for if the American Federation of Musicians is strong, its leader, James Caesar Petrillo (originally of Chicago) was also one of the more old-fashioned type of craft-union boss with a bare-knuckle strategy. Actually, the jazz musicians themselves—a small and specialized minority within the profession—have done much less to build up the union strength from which they have benefited than the despised pit-bandsmen and light musicians. And the iron hand of the union, where it is established, serves to keep everyone organized as well as to impose the union's will on the business. What difference a powerful organization, capable of imposing minimum scales, could make to the business is

obvious. But these advances have been won in Britain and the U.S.A. by a ruthless policy of restrictionism, or the creation of a guaranteed and protected field of jobs for live musicians in the union's area. This has sometimes diverted the entire course of jazz. The rigorous ban on the importation of foreign bands into Britain between 1935 and 1956—solo musicians could get in under the looser rules of the Variety Artistes' Federation—and the two-year shut-down on recordings which Petrillo imposed in America from 1942–4 are landmarks in jazz history. Both almost certainly did much to advance the 'traditionalist' jazz revival: the British union's ban by throwing British musicians on to their own resources (i.e. by leaving the British critics and jazz amateurs a clear field of influence), the American ban by bringing before the public numerous forgotten recordings from the companies' pre-1942 catalogues, which they were obliged to issue for want of any new ones. On the other hand the British ban almost certainly postponed the further evolution of British jazz by depriving our musicians of the chance of hearing good American artists in the flesh and playing with them: the startling acceleration in the evolution of British 'traditionalist' jazz towards a more ambitious music can almost certainly be put down to the influence of the two visits of Count Basie's band in 1957. The American ban, in its place, held up the evolution of 'modern' jazz, since it deprived the young New York experimenters of the chance of making records, and therefore winning a wider audience, until 1945.

If the musicians and writers formed their organizations, the businessmen developed the usual tendencies towards monopoly, though in so fluid a business as that of popular music, this was and is rarely very stable. The gramophone companies, of course, have long been a small and tight group, though one which does not exclude competition, and indeed encourages it. The point is, that while the production of gramophones and records can be tightly controlled by a small group of firms—in Britain there are two main groups, EMI and Decca—the production of successful artists cannot. There can never be any guarantee that an unknown singer or band, recorded by a marginal enterprise, and fancied by some popular disc jockey, may not turn out a hit and set a fashion, leaving the established companies in frantic search for a new side to their catalogues. For the mass production of such unpredictable

and changing commodities as hit tunes and hit artists still depends largely on general vigilance, guesswork, intuition, or plain luck. A label which virtually monopolized the good jazz, or the hits, in 1950 may find itself in 1958 with nothing but a back catalogue of unpopular music. For similar reasons agencies which succeed in cornering most good jazz bands at a time when they can be put under contract cheaply, and then sell them on their own terms, can have no guarantee that they may not be left with an unfashionable set of artists on their hands. The only safe form of monopoly in this business (apart from such technical ones as those in pressing facilities, shellac, record distribution, etc.) is the monopoly of booking. It is among the bookers that the tightest and most lasting controls have been established. Thus the Anglo-American band exchanges since 1956 have been largely handled by one or two British agencies, in close connexion with the American bookers. However, except on the gramophone side, the jazz and pop music business is so fluid, and requires relatively so little long-term investment of capital, that these monopolist tendencies make comparatively little difference to the general picture, which is one of old-fashioned cut-throat competition. Jazz and pop music in general is one of the last frontiers of private enterprise. On these rhythmic waves buccaneers of the old type can still sail their ships as gentlemen of fortune: out-smarting one another and anyone else, greasing palms, steering nimbly through the whirlpools of promoting, record making, publishing, managing, booking, plugging, and the rest. This is still the world in which smart young men can make it. The organization man, the tame psychologist, the economic adviser, are still far away. And so long as the cost of production of the hit tune or song, on which the industry rests, remains as low as it does (and that is a great deal lower than a film, a TV show, or a stage show), the jungle will continue to flourish in it, and the panthers will continue to prowl it, as they do the rather similar garment trade, enjoying the kill as much, and perhaps more, than the actual meal.

An important question remains: what effect on the actual music has this web of business and technology in which jazz is enmeshed? The answer is, a very considerable effect.

This is most easily seen by considering the most important technical medium of jazz, the gramophone record, without which the stylistic

evolution of jazz is quite unthinkable. It was (and still is) to this music what art galleries are to the art student and books to the aspiring writer: an essential educational institution. To this day the majority of jazz-lovers and players have learned their jazz largely from records, while musicians choose their style and train themselves by copying admired models on discs. This applies not only to deliberate movements of stylistic imitation like the 'New Orleans revival', which would certainly have been impossible but for the luck which made even very archaic jazz contemporary with the gramophone, and the prosperity of the American twenties, which even made blacks into record buyers. (Few black jazz records of that period would have been recorded then for the white market.) The educational influence of the record is universal. Without it, the living evolution of jazz would have been confined to limited groups of professional players or to particular cities in which there always happened to be good living jazz, as is proved by the failure of 'modern' jazz to exert much influence during the Second World War when, as it happened, recording was temporarily interrupted for a few years. If trumpeters in London and Tokyo are influenced by Armstrong, sax players by Charlie Parker, it is primarily due to the gramophone record.

The gramophone record has also made possible the permanent recording of much more flexible and experimental jazz than would otherwise have been possible. Regular bands, popular or jazz, have their established styles and repertoires which leave little room for dissidents, Paul Whiteman and Ted Lewis in the 1920s, whatever their private sympathies for 'hot' jazz—and both went out of their way to employ 'hot' players—could no more have started to play it officially than they could have started to play symphonies. Their public did not come to them for that. The specialized jazz band has similar problems: a passionate bopper in a Dixieland band, a passionate New Orleans man in a modern group (a much more unlikely contingency), must keep most of their enthusiasm to themselves. Mr Milt Jackson must play in the style of the Modern Jazz Quartet when with that group, whether he wants to or not. Mr. Humphrey Lyttelton, who has been brave enough to change his band from a 'traditionalist' to a 'middle period' unit, is engaged in interminable polemics with former members of his public who regard this change as treasonable. But the recording session with a 'pick-up'

band, or with a lasting group of men who normally played with other groups, filled this gap. (It also enabled musicians under exclusive contract somewhere else to play what they liked under pseudonyms, a fact which gives headaches to scholarly discographers. By now jazz expertise and popularity are so widespread that few musicians can get away with this, though recent examples still spring to mind.) Such purely studio groups have speeded up the evolution of jazz considerably, as witness Louis Armstrong's Hot Fives and Hot Sevens in the later 1920s. They have also ensured that artists otherwise buried in clubs or commercial bands became available on proper jazz records; e.g. the late Bix Beiderbecke. During the depression of 1929–34 the recorded history of jazz is largely confined to that of studio groups collected from time to time, like Spike Hughes's Negro Orchestra of 1933. In the 1930s the small *ad hoc* groups collected together by Benny Goodman—sometimes for live performance, sometimes only for sessions—were of equal importance: the trio, quartet, etc. In the early years of the bop revolution the fortunes of the new music depended primarily on studio groups. The jazz-lover must have a soft spot for them not only as an enthusiast but as a citizen, for it was in the studio that the colour bar was first effectively broken, thanks to the courage and initiative of men like Eddie Condon in the 1920s, John Hammond and Benny Goodman in the 1930s. Armstrong's *Knockin' a Jug* (1929) is not merely a superb record and a fine example of the flexibility which the pick-up band gave to jazz, but a monument to human progress as the first major jazz record made by a mixed black-white group.

From a purely commercial point of view the gramophone record also imposed a particular musical form on jazz composition: the three-minute miniature. For until the end of the 1940s the 78-rpm disc with that approximate playing time was virtually the only kind on which jazz was recorded, perhaps because the 12-inch, five-minute record was too expensive, perhaps because longer pieces, which involved changing records and breaking continuity, were unsuitable for dance-music, almost certainly because it was the cheapest economic unit of record production. Now three minutes is a highly artificial time for jazz. The single dance, which is the most obvious unit for such music, would normally last somewhere near ten minutes. A living creative jazz performance, as in a

jam session, might—without padding—go on for fifteen or twenty. However, since for more than a quarter of a century permanent jazz performances had to be compressed into the three-minute limit, musicians were obliged to invent an extremely dense, formally strict, concise form. They did so with extraordinary success. The late Constant Lambert was quite right to claim that no orthodox composer could compete with Duke Ellington within this length. But we have only to listen to any good jazz record of the pre-LP age to see that others were quite as successful in producing marvels of unity and shape: Armstrong, Morton, Basie, the Mezzrow-Bechet-Ladnier pick-up band. The classicism which business thus imposed on jazz had its advantages, for recent LPs show that jazz players, when left to themselves, are often tempted to run on—especially on instruments which lend themselves to continuous monologues, like the saxophone. Still, whatever the advantages and disadvantages of the three-minute strait-jacket—and Ellington for one never felt quite happy in it—it illustrates the musical repercussions of purely technological or business considerations.

The more general effects of the structure of the jazz business on the music are less easily described. The simplest way to tackle them is to consider aspects of jazz: the problem of musical education, the problem of style and repertoire, and the problem of musical creation.

The jazz business deals in the distribution of an available product: musicians. It does not deal in their production. Like all show business, it has always assumed that saleable players will just appear on the scene. Nothing like the conservatoire, or the classical ballet-school, has ever existed in jazz. Musicians have got their elementary education in playing instruments wherever they found it and their secondary and higher education by playing with other musicians. The production of a steady supply of first-class and fully mature players therefore depends on the existence of commercial bands which also happen to be sound 'educational' institutions. Consider the career of a jazzman of universally acknowledged 'finish'—the sort of man whom any bandleader is prepared to hire, who can be relied on to turn out an admirable mixture of technique and feeling with any combination, or on any session, the trombonist Vic Dickenson: not a genius, but the type of player without whom jazz could no more flourish than the theatre could flourish without

the first-rate character actor. He was born in 1906, began to play commercially at the age of sixteen, and got his education in the bands of Zach Whyte, Blanche Calloway, and Benny Moten and Claude Hopkins. In the forties he established himself as a highly individual talent, and he has since been the foundation stone of a wide stylistic variety of small combinations, studio bands, and superb recordings, and is equally admired by players of all schools.

Let us consider, on the other hand, the young European player who came up exclusively through the jazz movement and the young American player who is arriving today. The young European, if he entered music after say 1945, very likely played exclusively for a specialized jazz public and with specialist 'revivalist' or 'traditional' bands composed of other youngsters like himself, who had learned their music from records (older players, who were normally forced to go into ordinary commercial pre-war dance bands, generally received a much better technical training). He would rarely be forced to play alongside musicians who, though less learned about King Oliver, were technically far in advance of the amateurs. He would escape both the grind and the educational value of sight-reading, rehearsals, and the varied routine of dance-band playing. There is no doubt whatever that a number of talented European players have developed more slowly, and in some cases more one-sidedly, than they might have done, for want of such professionalism. The young American player of today suffers in a rather different way from the temporary eclipse of the large band which, in the later 1920s and 1930s, was the chief musical school of jazz. There, and there alone, could men learn that extraordinary capacity which makes a band like Count Basie's produce so dynamic a sound: that which enables a man not simply to be 'carried' by the rhythm of the rhythm instruments, but to swing individually and in sections. For (leaving aside 'traditionalist' jazz, which is virtually defunct in its homeland) small-group work or jam sessions are what emerges from jazz education; if they educate the player at all, it is only at the highest and most sophisticated level. He must be good already if he is to become better by small-group work. Mr Norman Granz, from whom I take some of these reflections, goes so far as to think that no player born after 1940 is likely to be fully 'educated' for this reason. I do not think such pessimism is warranted. Big bands may come

back, or other forms of training may evolve. But it is clear that the supply of first-rate musicians must depend on what are essentially commercial phenomena.

The problem of style, repertoire, and creation can be discussed together. Here the essential point is that good jazz requires an audience which does not get in the way of the players too much. If players and public are naturally at one, as in the classic days of New Orleans, there is no problem. If they are not, then the players perform best when providing for the minimum needs of the public—dancing, background noise, atmosphere—while enjoying themselves or experimenting in their own way. This was relatively easy when commercial ‘pop’ music was the main burden they had to carry. Today, however, a commercial public has grown up which requires jazz as jazz, and as we have seen, this provides for the players’ livelihood. They are obliged to play in particular ‘styles’ even if they may want to play differently. They are besieged with demands for ‘request numbers’ and therefore forced to repeat, time and again, a limited group of standards until they are sick of them: *When the Saints Go Marching In*, *Trouble in Mind*, or *The Bucket’s Got a Hole in It* among the revivalists; *Cherokee*, *How High the Moon*, *Body and Soul* among the modernists. There is not much to be said in favour of the routine pop ‘ballad’, but it does change all the time. Miserable though the Tin Pan Alley repertoire is, it does at least confront the musician with a constantly new set of challenges: themes which he ought to turn into something interesting and from among which, perhaps, he can select one or two which lend themselves to a more lasting process of transformation. A jazz style and a jazz repertoire imposed by a would-be expert public is as constricting to the musician as an exclusive insistence on Grieg and Tchaikovsky is to classical orchestras.

What is worse, the jazz public insists, against all logic, on the impossible achievement of spontaneous creation to order. Every jazz musician is forced to become a sort of nightly poet laureate, who guarantees a supply of odes on fixed dates and occasions. It is no use pointing out that the phrase ‘concert jam session’ is a contradiction in terms; that the safest way to turn creation into routine is to announce that it will take place every evening between eight and twelve in a particular cellar. In itself this would not be serious, for it is fairly easy for musicians

to dress up routine as spontaneous creation, especially with a little loud blowing and hard drumming in small enclosed spaces. The musicians might well do so, and then go away, as they have long done, and jam for their own pleasure in some after-hours night spot. And yet the very devaluation of creation and improvisation which the rise of the specialist jazz public has imposed in working hours risks devaluing it outside. Musicians may lose interest in it, and flee into carefully rehearsed and arranged jazz (which has its own merits), as many tend to do. Or else they may carry the routine tricks of working hours into the times when they really feel like improvising, or ought to improvise.

The growing flood of jazz which has actually to be performed and recorded to meet the existing demand merely intensifies these problems, particularly on record. After all, the entire output of Louis Armstrong's Hot Five and Hot Seven, which produced a score of masterpieces, consists of sixty sides on a dozen or so sessions spread over four years. In a single year fifty tracks made by Armstrong in 1955 were released in Britain.⁷ Mr Ruby Braff, a good trumpeter, produced at least forty tracks between March and October 1955. I do not claim that such over-production produces bad jazz. Good professionals can be relied upon to produce a good average level. But a good average level by musicians playing a good solid routine is merely the bread and butter of jazz. And by the very nature of their changing music, jazz players depend, much more than 'straight' ones, on the chicken in the sandwich: the mood, the inspiration, the combination of circumstances which turn routine into joy.

These remarks are not intended to arouse alarm and despondency, but merely to show that the musical character and prospects of jazz cannot be divorced from its character and prospects as a business. If jazz were ever to be standardized into purely composed and 'executed' forms (when it would cease to be jazz as we know it), it might avoid these difficulties. It might then have no more troubles than the symphony orchestra, which, like the licensed Ford dealer, sells a known and branded commodity for which a permanent and relatively unchanging demand exists. The repertoire which fills halls may be rather more limited, the versions which appeal to the public a shade more florid than musicians might like, but within those limits they play what they consider 'good' music. But

the jazz group cannot afford to become a dealer in standardized commodities, partly because its commodity (creating music while it plays) dies once it is standardized, partly because the music itself constantly changes and evolves. The jazz player, if he has any sense, is reconciled to playing standardized stuff most of the time, for that is his business as a professional entertainer; and if he is sensible, he will also enjoy performing as the actor does, though he is less completely dependent on the audience. But he has also generally had a large ‘free’ margin—inside and out of hours—when he could play as he pleased. Within that margin he could be overheard by the public, with luck, though he was not performing or only half performing for it. It is the gradual conquest of this margin by the jazz business (by you and me, the jazz public) which has led him into a quandary in the past twenty years. He has not escaped from it yet.

Notes

1. Blesh and Janis, 60–3; Handy, 91; *Hear Me Talkin’ ...*, 261, 301–2.
2. Taken from A. J. McCarthy, *Jazz Discography*, 1958. Strictly speaking the figures we refer to records released during the year.
3. The High Finance of Jazz, in *Rhythm*, January 1939.
4. W. C. Allen and B. Rust *Joe King Oliver* (London 1958).
5. R. Gleason in *San Francisco Chronicle*, 6 November 1960, *New York Post*, 18 November 1960, p. 56.
6. Feather, *Encyclopedia*.
7. *Early Armstrong from Jazz Magazine* III, 3 (1947), 1955 records from *Jazz Discography* 1956 in *Just Jazz I* (1957).

* Occasional or limited entertainment, such as guild pageants and passion plays in medieval cities or a coronation today, need not be professionalized to the same extent.

† Companies are extraordinarily cagey about producing hard facts and figures, unless they show them to be both (a) selling and (b) making next to no money. I owe the following estimates—which I reproduce for what they are worth—to a friend with a great deal of experience in the business.

‡ For those who like figures the following estimates may be useful:

A. SHORT-PLAYING RECORD

Selling-price (1958) of copy	\$0.84
Cost per copy: Distribution	0.33
Package	0.02
Labels	0.02

Artist's Royalty	0.03
Publisher's Royalty	0.035
Musicians (at 2,000 sales), total \$95.20	per copy 0.05
Studio cost (\$28.00 a title at 2,000 sales)	per copy 0.03
Purchase Tax	0.21
Maker's margin, overheads, publicity	0.14
\$95.20 should have sufficed in 1958 for a half-session at union scale (i.e., \$12.60 per player, \$19.60 for the leader). Overheads per single record were obviously small, but publicity may have come high.	

§ For the financially minded reader an example may be instructive. It is taken from Ralph Gleason's column in the *San Francisco Chronicle* (26 June 1960) and analyses an actual concert by Duke Ellington and Sarah Vaughan:

Capacity of house: \$21,000

Expenditure: \$10,043. (Rent of hall \$435, Lights and light men \$150, Public address system \$87, Tickets \$132, Doormen, etc., \$225, Special police \$90, Stand-by musicians \$314, City licence \$10, Advance box office \$300, Insurance \$50, Advertising and promotion \$3000, Talent, \$5250.

In fact—such are the risks of the business—the takings were only \$5,100.